

A mathematical modelling of rheumatoid arthritis

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We model the interaction between three populations of cells in the context of arthritis, namely the neutrophils, the tissue resident macrophages (SubLining Tissue Resident Macrophages) and the Monocyte Macrophages. The SL-TRM macrophage cells reside in the outer border of the joint. The Momac (monocytes-macrophages) cells are coming from the reservoir of monocytes in the marrow. Basically the crisis scenario is the following: The arthritis crisis is triggered by an external signal (injection of immune serum containing antigens) that activates the immune system and provokes an inflammatory response. The antigens are recognized by the macrophages L-TRM (lining tissue resident macrophages) cells that secrete inflammatory chemokines and cytokines. These cytokines activate the fibroblasts which in turn recruit the neutrophils cells from the blood stream into the joint. The cytokines also recruit the Momac cells from the blood stream into the joint. There is a positive feedback since the inflammation is amplified by the neutrophils that are recruited in the joint by the chemokines secreted by the Momac cells. The macrophages SL-TRM cells have a protective role since they inhibit the inflammation but they are depleted during the crisis because they are penalized by the proliferation of Momac cells.

1 Model

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1.1 Mathematical Model

Let us denote by $T(t)$ the population of SL-TRM cells and by $M(t)$ the population of Momac cells at time t . The cells T (SL-TRM) and M (Momac) interact with each other in the following way. The Momac cells M are recruited from the blood stream at a constant rate a . They die at a rate δ_M and they transform into SL-TRM cells at a rate b . The SL-TRM cells T die at a rate δ_T . The interaction between the two populations is described by the following system of differential equations

The inflammatory state $S(t)$ is enhanced by neutrophils N and inhibited by SL-TRM macrophages T .

Inflammation further increases neutrophils (factor α), increases Momac (factor β), and decreases SL-TRM (factor γ).

Notice that we do not keep track of the population of fibroblasts, but rather the population of neutrophils, which are recruited by inflammatory chemokines.

The variable $N(t)$ designates the population of neutrophils at time t . Finally $S(t)$ is the inflammatory signal at time t . The model is given by the following system of ordinary differential equations:

$$\begin{cases} \frac{dS}{dt} = (aN - bT)S \\ \frac{dN}{dt} = \alpha SN - \delta_N N(N - 1) \\ \frac{dM}{dt} = \beta S - \delta_M M(M - 1) \\ \frac{dT}{dt} = -\gamma ST + \delta_M M(1 - T) \end{cases} \quad (1)$$

where $a, b, \alpha, \beta, \gamma, \delta_N, \delta_M$ are positive parameters. To make things easier to understand, we summarize the model in the following diagram (see Figure 1.1).

Remark (Comments and questions on the model):

- to be discussed with our immunologists collaborators

2 Analysis of the model

2.1 Equilibria points

Equilibria points of the system are found by setting the right-hand side of the system to zero, i.e. by solving the following system of equations: 01 The equilibrium points (S^*, N^*, M^*, T^*) satisfy the following system:

$$(aN^* - bT^*)S^* = 0 \quad (2)$$

$$\alpha S^* N^* - \delta_N N^*(N^* - 1) = 0 \quad (3)$$

$$\beta S^* - \delta_M M^*(M^* - 1) = 0 \quad (4)$$

$$-\gamma S^* T^* + \delta_M M^*(1 - T^*) = 0 \quad (5)$$

This gives the following equilibria points. A first natural equilibrium point is given by $S^* = 0, N^* = 1, M^* = 1, T^* = 1$. This point corresponds to the disease-free state, where there is no inflammation ($S^* = 0$) and the populations of neutrophils, Momac,

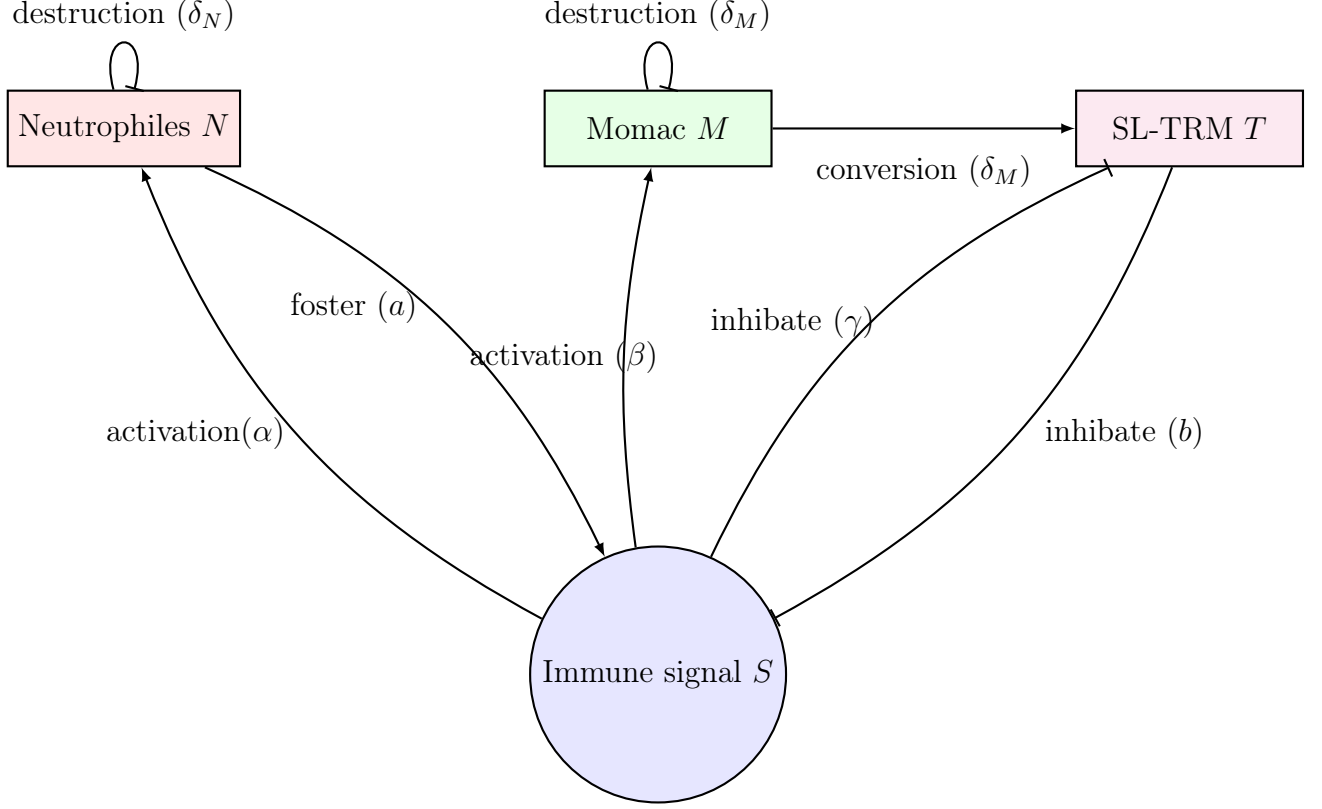


Figure 1: Schematic representation of the model

and SL-TRM are at their baseline levels ($N^* = 1, M^* = 1, T^* = 1$). There are other equilibria points with $S^* = 0$ namely $S^* = 0, N^* = 0, M^* = 0, T^* = t$, with arbitrary t ; $S^* = 0, N^* = 0, M^* = 1, T^* = 1$; $S^* = 0, N^* = 1, M^* = 0, T^* = t$, with arbitrary t .

For equilibria points with $S^* \neq 0$, from equation (2) we have $aN^* - bT^* = 0$, hence

$$T^* = \frac{a}{b}N^*. \quad (6)$$

Factoring N^* from equation (3), we obtain:

$$N^* (\alpha S^* - \delta_N(N^* - 1)) = 0$$

This gives us two possibilities: either $N^* = 0$ or $\alpha S^* - \delta_N(N^* - 1) = 0$. If $N^* = 0$, then from equation (2) we have $a \cdot 0 - bT^* = 0$, hence $T^* = 0$. From equation (5), we get $M^* = 0$. Then from equation (4), we have $\beta S^* - \delta_M \cdot 0 = 0$, hence $S^* = 0$. This contradicts our assumption that $S^* \neq 0$. Therefore, the case $N^* = 0$ is not possible for equilibria with $S^* \neq 0$. Therefore $\alpha S^* - \delta_N(N^* - 1) = 0$, so we can express S^* in terms of N^* :

$$S^* = \frac{\delta_N}{\alpha}(N^* - 1) \quad (7)$$

We substitute (6)-(7) into equation (4) and (5) and obtain a 2 by 2 system for M^* and N^* : By substituting $T^* = \frac{a}{b}N^*$ and $S^* = \frac{\delta_N}{\alpha}(N^* - 1)$ into the equilibrium equations for

M^* and T^* , we obtain the following system for N^* and M^* :

$$\begin{cases} \beta \frac{\delta_N}{\alpha} (N^* - 1) - \delta_M M^* (M^* - 1) = 0 \\ -\gamma \frac{\delta_N}{\alpha} (N^* - 1) \cdot \frac{a}{b} N^* + \delta_M M^* \left(1 - \frac{a}{b} N^*\right) = 0 \end{cases}$$

This system allows us to determine the equilibrium values N^* and M^* when $S^* \neq 0$. Indeed we can express N^* in terms of M^* from the first equation:

$$N^* = 1 + \frac{\alpha \delta_M}{\beta \delta_N} M^* (M^* - 1) \quad (8)$$

Substituting this expression for N^* into the second equation, we obtain an equation for M^* :

$$M^* = \frac{a \gamma \delta_N}{b \alpha \delta_M} \frac{N^* (N^* - 1)}{(1 - \frac{a}{b} N^*)} \quad (9)$$

Geometrically, the equilibria points with $S^* \neq 0$ correspond to the intersection points of the parabola defined by equations (8) and the hyperbola defined by equation (9) in the (N^*, M^*) plane. The number of such intersection points (and hence the number of equilibria with $S^* \neq 0$) depends on the parameters of the model. Substituting (8) into (9), we would obtain a quartic equation in N^* , which we do not write explicitly here due to its complexity. From basic algebra, we can show that there are at most 4 such intersection points, hence at most 4 equilibria points with $S^* \neq 0$. We can be more precise because the biological feasibility imposes the roots to be real nonnegative numbers. Due to the structure of the irreducible polynomial on $\mathbb{R}$ we can have either 0, or 2, or 4 real roots. We can find the asymptotes of the hyperbola and the apex of the parabola to determine the possible number of intersection points in the first quadrant. We rewrite the equation (9) of the hyperbola as follows:

$$-\frac{\gamma \delta_N}{\alpha \delta_M} (N^* + b/a - 1) + \frac{(b/a)^2 (1 - b/a)}{(N^* - b/a)} \quad (10)$$

From this expression, we see that the hyperbola has a vertical asymptote at $N^* = b/a$ and an oblique asymptote at $M^* = -\frac{\gamma \delta_N}{\alpha \delta_M} (N^* + b/a - 1)$. The parabola (8) is horizontal in the N, M plane, has its apex at $N_{min} = 1 - \frac{\alpha \delta_M}{4\beta \delta_N}$ and $M = 1/2$ and is symmetric with respect to the horizontal line $M = 1/2$ and opens eastwards. We plot some typical cases in the following figure. Notice that we need only 4 *non dimensional* parameters a/b , α/β , γ/α , and δ_N/δ_M instead of the 7 original parameters.

2.2 Stability analysis

Stability analysis of the equilibria point (S^*, N^*, M^*, T^*) is done by linearizing the system around this point. The Jacobian matrix of the system is given by:

$$J = \begin{pmatrix} aN - bT & aS & 0 & -bS \\ \alpha N & \alpha S - \delta_N(2N - 1) & 0 & 0 \\ \beta & 0 & -\delta_M(2M - 1) & 0 \\ -\gamma T & 0 & \delta_M(1 - T) & -\gamma S - \delta_M M \end{pmatrix}$$

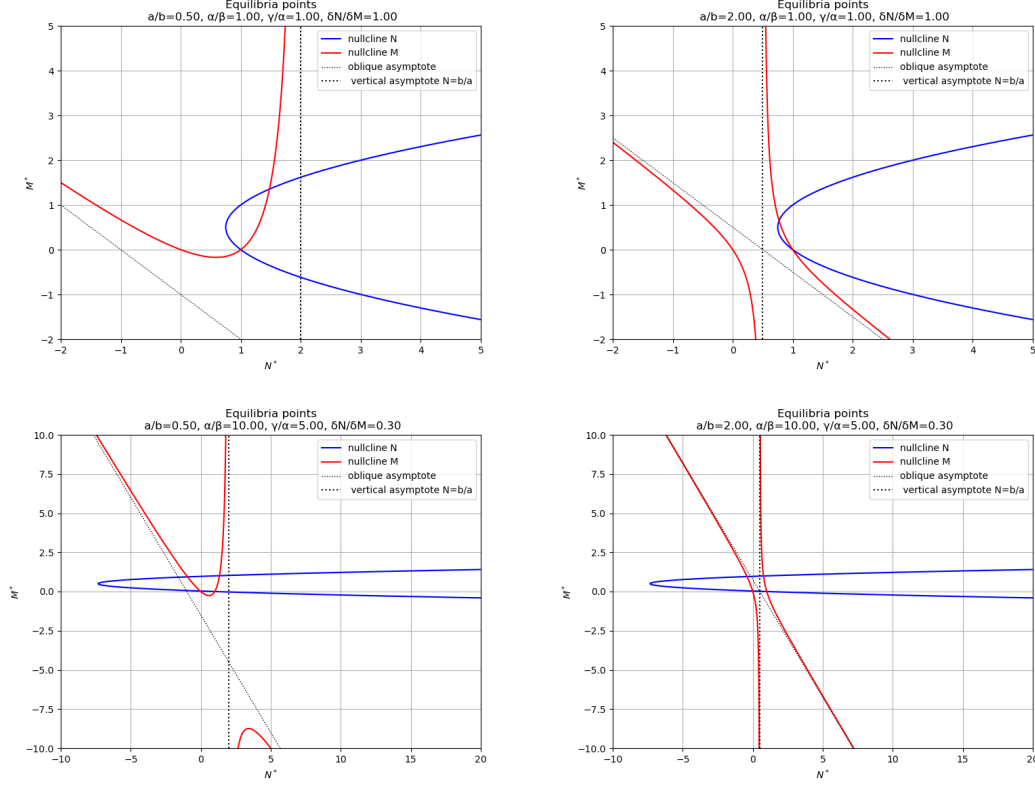


Figure 2: equilibria in the (N^*, M^*) plane, left $a < b$, right $a > b$.

We analyze first the stability of the disease-free equilibrium point $(S^*, N^*, M^*, T^*) = (0, 1, 1, 1)$. At this point, the Jacobian matrix simplifies to:

$$J|_{(S^*, N^*, M^*, T^*)=(0,1,1,1)} = \begin{pmatrix} a-b & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ \alpha & -\delta_N & 0 & 0 \\ \beta & 0 & -\delta_M & 0 \\ -\gamma & 0 & 0 & -\delta_M \end{pmatrix}$$

We notice immediately that the eigenvalues of this matrix are $a-b$, $-\delta_N$ and $-\delta_M$. The last two are negative since $\delta_N, \delta_M > 0$. The remaining eigenvalue is $a-b$. Thus the disease-free equilibrium is stable if $a < b$ and unstable if $a > b$. This means that if the inflammatory effect of Neutrophils cells controlled by parameter a is less than the curing effect of the SL-TRM macrophages controlled by parameter b , the system will return to the disease-free state. Conversely, if $a > b$, the system may move away from this equilibrium, potentially leading to a chronic inflammatory state. The stability of other equilibria points can be analyzed similarly by evaluating the Jacobian matrix at those points and determining the eigenvalues.

For $S^* = 0, N^* = 0, M^* = 0, T^* = t$, with arbitrary t , the Jacobian matrix becomes:

$$J|_{(S^*, N^*, M^*, T^*)=(0,0,0,t)} = \begin{pmatrix} -bt & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & \delta_N & 0 & 0 \\ \beta & 0 & \delta_M & 0 \\ -\gamma t & 0 & \delta_M(1-t) & 0 \end{pmatrix}$$

The eigenvalues of this matrix are $-bt$, δ_N , δ_M , and 0. Since δ_N and δ_M are positive, this equilibrium point is unstable. Even if the immune signal will decrease exponentially

fast, the populations of neutrophils and momac will grow out of bound. This unstable equilibrium will not be observed in practice.

For $S^* = 0, N^* = 0, M^* = 1, T^* = 1$, the Jacobian matrix is:

$$J|_{(S^*, N^*, M^*, T^*)=(0,0,1,1)} = \begin{pmatrix} -b & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & \delta_N & 0 & 0 \\ \beta & 0 & -\delta_M & 0 \\ -\gamma & 0 & 0 & -\delta_M \end{pmatrix}$$

The eigenvalues of this matrix are $-b$, δ_N , $-\delta_M$, and $-\gamma$. Since there is a positive eigenvalue, this equilibrium point is unstable. Neutrophils can grow out of bound. This equilibrium will not be observed in practice neither.

For $S^* = 0, N^* = 1, M^* = 0, T^* = t$, with arbitrary t , the Jacobian matrix is

$$J|_{(S^*, N^*, M^*, T^*)=(0,1,0,t)} = \begin{pmatrix} -bt & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ \alpha & -\delta_N & 0 & 0 \\ \beta & 0 & \delta_M & 0 \\ -\gamma t & 0 & \delta_M(1-t) & 0 \end{pmatrix}$$

There is a positive eigenvalue δ_M , hence this equilibrium point is unstable. Momac can grow out of bound. This equilibrium will not be observed in practice neither.

3 Numerical simulations

Here we reproduce one typical simulations of the model using the following parameters: $\alpha = 1, \beta = 1, \gamma = 1, \delta_N = 1, \delta_M = 1, a = 0.35, b = 1$, duration=20 days and initial conditions $S(0) = 1, N(0) = 1, M(0) = 1, T(0) = 1$.

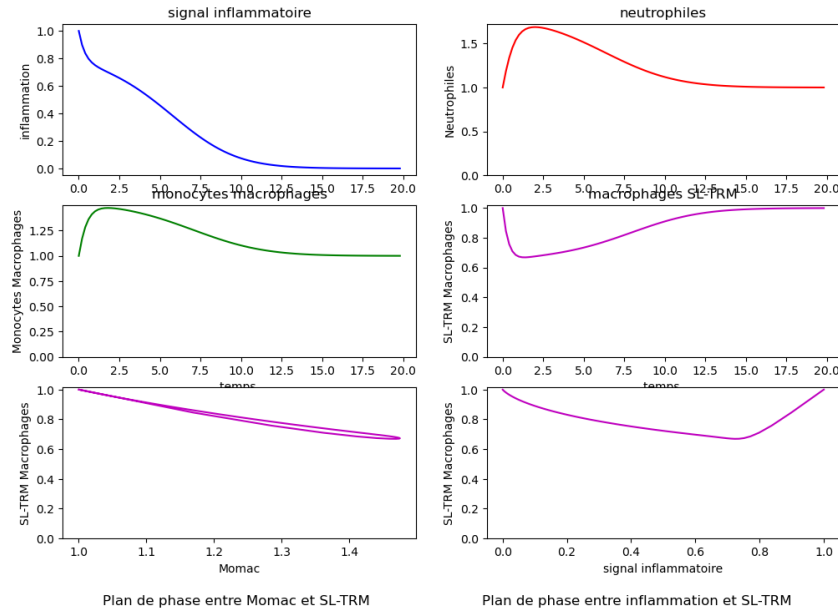


Figure 3:

We need to have realistic values for the parameters to feed the model.

The Python Jupyter notebook used to perform the simulations is available at <https://github.com/azerad/immunomath>.

3.1 Bifurcation analysis

We perform a bifurcation analysis with respect to the *non dimensional* parameters a/b , α/β , γ/α , and δ_N/δ_M . We vary a in the interval $[0, 1]$ and b in the interval $[0.1, 2]$. For each pair (a, b) , we simulate the system for 20 days and we record the value of S at the final time. The results are shown in the following heatmap.

Acknowledgments

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